

Fishing Near Columbus — 30 Spots with Species & Bait

Thirty places to wet a line within an easy drive of Columbus. Bring a valid **Ohio fishing license**, then use each spot's **fish**, **bait**, **website** (when there is one), and local tip.

Before you go

- ☐ Current Ohio fishing license — [ODNR licenses](#)
- ☐ Check size/bag limits for what you're keeping — [ODNR fishing regulations](#)
- ☐ Rod + reel, spare hooks/soft plastics, pliers, net for bigger water
- ☐ Sunscreen, water, bug spray (summer), warm layers (shoulder seasons)
- ☐ Trash bag — pack out what you pack in

License note: This guide is not a substitute for ODNR regulations. Access and rules change — confirm posted park/reservoir rules the morning of your trip.

How to use: Circle 2–3 nearby spots, pick a half-day window, and leave if pressure or weather turns.

Bait cheat sheet (central Ohio favorites)

Target	Often works
Bluegill / sunfish	Worms, waxworms, tiny jigs, small spinners
Crappie	Minnows, 1/16-oz jigs + soft plastics, small tubes
Largemouth / smallmouth bass	Soft plastics (worms/creature baits), spinnerbaits, crankbaits, topwater (warm months)
Saugeye / walleye	Jigs + minnows or soft plastics, crankbaits along drop-offs
Channel / blue / flathead catfish	Cut bait, chicken liver, nightcrawlers, stink baits (channel); live/cut bait deeper for blues/flatheads
White bass	Small spinners, spoons, shad-imitating soft plastics
Carp	Corn, dough balls, worms (where legal / ethical for the water)

Reservoirs & big water

1. Hoover Reservoir — Westerville / NE Columbus

Fish: Crappie (black & white), channel / blue / flathead catfish, largemouth & smallmouth bass, saugeye, bluegill, white bass.

Bait: Crappie — minnows or 1/16-oz jigs + soft plastics near cover; catfish — cut bait / liver on the north end; bass — plastics & crankbaits; saugeye — jigs/crankbaits on drop-offs.

Web: [ODNR — Hoover Reservoir Fishing Area](#)

Local tip: Pick one arm and fish it well. 10 HP outboard limit. Westerville food/coffee ~10 minutes from most ramps.

Nearby: Blendon Woods / Inniswood if you want a short walk.

2. Alum Creek Lake — Lewis Center / Delaware County

Fish: Largemouth & smallmouth bass, saugeye, crappie, channel catfish, bluegill.

Bait: Bass — soft plastics in weeds (3–10 ft) or topwater; smallmouth — plastics/crankbaits on points & rock; crappie — minnows/jigs; catfish — cut bait / crawlers.

Web: [ODNR — Alum Creek Lake Fishing Area](#) · [Alum Creek State Park](#)

Local tip: Weekday mornings beat weekend boat traffic. Confirm ramp/lot status seasonally.

Nearby: Lewis Center / Polaris for food after you load up.

3. Griggs Reservoir — NW Columbus

Fish: Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish; occasional hybrid striped bass / white bass reports.

Bait: Worms & small jigs for panfish; soft plastics / spinnerbaits for bass; cut bait or crawlers for cats along deeper edges.

Web: [City of Columbus — Griggs Reservoir Park](#)

Local tip: Shared path with bikes/kayaks — keep casts and gear tidy.

Nearby: UA / Hilliard lunch along Fishinger / Trabue corridors.

4. O'Shaughnessy Reservoir — Dublin / NW

Fish: Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

Bait: Soft plastics & spinnerbaits for bass; worms/jigs for bluegill & crappie; cut bait for cats.

Web: [City of Columbus — O'Shaughnessy Reservoir Park](#)

Local tip: Wind pushes hard — fish protected pockets when gusty.

Nearby: Historic Dublin / Bridge Park for coffee and a walk.

5. Buckeye Lake — SE of Columbus

Fish: Largemouth bass, crappie, bluegill, channel catfish, saugeye (varies by year).

Bait: Plastics & spinnerbaits for bass; minnows/jigs for crappie; crawlers/cut bait for cats.

Web: [Buckeye Lake State Park](#)

Local tip: Summer weekends are crowded — dawn or weekday. Confirm public access vs private docks.

Nearby: Lake-town food; don't assume every dock is public.

6. Delaware Lake — Delaware State Park

Fish: Largemouth bass, crappie, bluegill, channel catfish, saugeye.

Bait: Soft plastics for bass; minnows/jigs for crappie; crawlers/cut bait for cats; jigs along deeper structure for saugeye.

Web: [Delaware State Park](#)

Local tip: Pair fishing with a park picnic; check launch fees/hours.

Nearby: Downtown Delaware for a sit-down meal.

7. Deer Creek Lake — Deer Creek State Park

Fish: Largemouth bass, crappie, bluegill, channel catfish, saugeye / hybrid striped bass (check current ODNR notes).

Bait: Plastics & crankbaits for bass; minnows/jigs for crappie; cut bait for cats; spoons/jigs for open-water hybrids when active.

Web: [Deer Creek State Park](#)

Local tip: Plan a half- or full-day trip — farther than metro ponds. Gas up in Columbus.

Nearby: Pack snacks; park amenities are the main food option.

8. Madison Lake — Madison Lake State Park

Fish: Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

Bait: Worms & tiny jigs (great for kids/bluegill); soft plastics for bass; cut bait/crawlers for cats.

Web: [Madison Lake State Park](#)

Local tip: Easier to "read" than huge reservoirs — ideal teach-a-friend water.

Nearby: Pack a cooler; amenities are park-basic.

Metro Parks lakes & ponds

9. Sharon Woods Metro Park

Fish: Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish (lake).

Bait: Worms / small jigs for panfish; soft plastics for bass; crawlers for cats.

Web: [Sharon Woods](#)

Local tip: Share shore with walkers; early morning is calmer.

Nearby: Park restrooms + Westerville food.

10. Antrim Park — Worthington

Fish: Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

Bait: Worms & bobbers for bluegill; small plastics for bass; liver/crawlers for cats.

Web: [Antrim Park \(City of Columbus\)](#)

Local tip: After-work friendly — travel light; geese are part of the deal.

Nearby: Worthington / High Street food.

11. Rocky Fork Metro Park

Fish: Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie (where fishing is posted).

Bait: Worms, small jigs, soft plastics.

Web: [Rocky Fork](#)

Local tip: Confirm fishing-allowed shoreline vs wildlife-only zones.

Nearby: Gahanna / New Albany food corridors.

12. Pickerington Ponds Metro Park

Fish: Panfish and bass in ponds where fishing is allowed (confirm posts — some wetland areas are wildlife-first).

Bait: Worms, tiny jigs, small soft plastics.

Web: [Pickerington Ponds](#)

Local tip: Soft banks after rain; bring binoculars either way.

Nearby: Pickerington snacks/groceries.

13. Glacier Ridge Metro Park

Fish: Bluegill, bass, and pond panfish where posted.

Bait: Worms, small jigs, soft plastics.

Web: [Glacier Ridge](#)

Local tip: Little shade — summer heat is real.

Nearby: Dublin / Plain City food depending on entrance.

14. Prairie Oaks Metro Park — Big Darby corridor

Fish: Smallmouth / rock bass / sunfish in creek sections where fishing is allowed (Darby is a sensitive system — obey all posts).

Bait: Light tackle — small inline spinners, soft plastics, worms (no heavy gear).

Web: [Prairie Oaks](#)

Local tip: After storms, wait for clearer, safer water.

Nearby: West-side / Hilliard food; prairie walk if the bite dies.

15. Battelle Darby Creek Metro Park

Fish: Creek sunfish, bass species where posted; some areas are catch-and-release or closed — read signs.

Bait: Light spinning gear — worms, tiny spinners, small plastics.

Web: [Battelle Darby Creek](#)

Local tip: Stay out of restricted/sensitive zones.

Nearby: Nature center for orientation; pack lunch.

16. Three Creeks Metro Park

Fish: Creek sunfish, bass, occasional catfish in deeper holes.

Bait: Worms, small jigs, soft plastics, light spinners.

Web: [Three Creeks](#)

Local tip: After heavy rain, current spikes — safety first.

Nearby: South/east Columbus food; easy 90-minute stop.

17. Blacklick Woods Metro Park

Fish: Pond/creek panfish and bass where fishing is posted.

Bait: Worms, tiny jigs, soft plastics.

Web: [Blacklick Woods](#)

Local tip: Roots and mud — grip shoes beat flip-flops.

Nearby: East-side food on Brice / Main corridors.

18. Scioto Audubon Metro Park

Fish: Urban river/pond access for bass, panfish, and catfish where posted.

Bait: Soft plastics for bass; worms for panfish; cut bait for cats.

Web: [Scioto Audubon](#)

Local tip: Perfect “one hour after work” stop — park once, travel light.

Nearby: Brewery District / German Village after you rinse off.

19. Homestead Park — Hilliard

Fish: Bluegill, bass, channel catfish (pond).

Bait: Worms under a bobber (kid-friendly); small plastics for bass; liver/crawlers for cats.

Web: [Homestead Park \(Hilliard\)](#)

Local tip: First-bluegill day water — quit while it's still fun.

Nearby: Old Hilliard / Hilliard Rome food.

20. Darby Creek park access (metro west)

Fish: Sunfish, smallmouth/rock bass where public fishing is posted.

Bait: Ultra-light — worms, tiny spinners, small plastics.

Web: Start at [Prairie Oaks](#) / [Battelle Darby Creek](#) for legal access points

Local tip: Public park access only — no private banks.

Nearby: Combine with a short trail if fishing slows.

Rivers & creeks (public access only)

21. Scioto River — Griggs to downtown corridor

Fish: Smallmouth bass, channel catfish, freshwater drum, carp, sunfish; seasonal white bass / sauger-family fish depending on stretch.

Bait: Soft plastics & small crankbaits for smallmouth; cut bait / crawlers for cats; corn/dough where carp fishing is practiced.

Web: Corridor parks via [Columbus Recreation & Parks](#) · [Griggs](#)

Local tip: Pick one public park access — don't hop fences. Summer evenings can be excellent.

Nearby: Grandview / Franklinton / downtown food by exit point.

22. Scioto River — south of downtown (public parks)

Fish: Channel catfish, smallmouth, drum, carp, sunfish.

Bait: Cut bait and nightcrawlers for cats; plastics for bass; worms for panfish.

Web: [Columbus Recreation & Parks](#)

Local tip: Watch footing on riprap; tell someone your plan.

Nearby: South Side / German Village for a victory meal.

23. Olentangy River — Worthington / Clintonville

Fish: Smallmouth bass, sunfish, channel catfish, carp.

Bait: Light plastics & spinners for smallmouth; worms for sunfish; cut bait for cats.

Web: Trail/park context via [Columbus Recreation & Parks](#) · nearby [Highbanks Metro Park](#) (river corridor north)

Local tip: Bike-path traffic is high — cast with awareness.

Nearby: Clintonville coffee and High Street food.

24. Olentangy River — north toward Delaware County

Fish: Smallmouth, sunfish, catfish; clearer water pockets after stable weather.

Bait: Soft plastics, small crankbaits, worms, cut bait.

Web: Confirm each lot via [Delaware County / ODNR maps](#) before you go

Local tip: Mix of park and private land — public lots only.

Nearby: Powell / Delaware food on the drive.

25. Big Walnut Creek — east / southeast parks

Fish: Smallmouth / rock bass, sunfish, channel catfish.

Bait: Light plastics & spinners; worms; cut bait in deeper holes.

Web: Park pages vary by stretch — start with [Three Creeks](#) / city park listings

Local tip: After storms, wait for safer levels and clearer water.

Nearby: Gahanna / Reynoldsburg / Canal Winchester by stretch.

26. Alum Creek — below-dam / creek sections (public only)

Fish: Smallmouth, sunfish, catfish; dam areas can hold seasonal runners — follow special rules.

Bait: Soft plastics, small jigs, worms, cut bait.

Web: [Alum Creek State Park](#) · [Alum Creek Lake Fishing Area](#)

Local tip: Dam current is dangerous — read every sign.

Nearby: Westerville / Lewis Center for supplies.

27. Blacklick Creek — east-side park access

Fish: Sunfish, small bass, occasional catfish.

Bait: Ultra-light worms, tiny jigs, small spinners.

Web: Nearby park hubs: [Blacklick Woods](#) · [Three Creeks](#)

Local tip: Small water = light tackle and patience.

Nearby: East Columbus for bait/snacks.

Easy day-trip & “worth the drive” options

28. A.W. Marion State Park — Circleville area

Fish: Largemouth bass, bluegill, crappie, channel catfish.

Bait: Worms & small jigs; soft plastics for bass; cut bait for cats.

Web: [A.W. Marion State Park](#)

Local tip: Half-day outing; check park hours before you leave.
Nearby: Circleville for a simple meal on the way back.

29. Slate Run Metro Park

Fish: Pond panfish and bass **only where fishing is posted** (some park water is wildlife-only).
Bait: Worms, tiny jigs, soft plastics.
Web: [Slate Run](#)
Local tip: Confirm allowed ponds before you cast; trails make a fine backup plan.
Nearby: Southeast suburbs for gas and food.

30. Chestnut Ridge Metro Park

Fish: Panfish / bass where posted on park waters.
Bait: Worms, small jigs, soft plastics.
Web: [Chestnut Ridge](#)
Local tip: Combine with a short ridge walk so the day isn't only waiting on a bite.
Nearby: Southeast suburbs before you head north.

Half-day sampler menus

NE Columbus: Hoover → Sharon Woods → Westerville food
NW metro: Griggs or O'Shaughnessy → Dublin coffee
East side: Rocky Fork or Pickerington Ponds → Gahanna/Pickerington bite
Teach-a-kid: Homestead Park or Madison Lake → pack snacks → quit early
Day-trip: Deer Creek or Delaware Lake — leave early, home by dinner

Gear quick list

- ☐ License + ID
- ☐ Rod/reel + spare line
- ☐ Hooks, sinkers, bobbers, soft plastics, nightcrawlers (as allowed)
- ☐ Pliers / clippers / net / measuring device
- ☐ Cooler + ice (if keeping)
- ☐ Headlamp for dawn/dusk
- ☐ First-aid basics

Trip log

Date	Spot # / name	Target fish	Bait used	Caught?	Notes

Favorite of the 30: _____
Best bait day: _____
Next spot to try: _____

success, links, and access change — confirm license rules, limits, and posted park/reservoir rules before you go.